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AFP

DECEPTIVE CAMARADERIE PM Modi with US president Donald Trump at the White House, Feb. 13

▶ INDO-US TIES

DEALING WITH THE TRUMP SHOCKER

As Trump hands out a punitive 50 per cent tariff on India, the government crafts a measured response while protecting Indian interests

By RAJ CHENGAPPA

NOT SINCE BILL CLINTON IN 1998, WHEN he threatened to "come down like a ton of bricks" after India conducted its nuclear tests, has a serving US president spoken so derogatorily about India as Donald Trump did in a series of posts on Truth Social recently. On July 30, Trump accused India of having "the most strenuous and obnoxious non-monetary Trade Barriers for any Country" and then went on to add that India is "Russia's largest buyer of energy, along with China, at a time when everyone wants Russia TO STOP THE KILLING IN UKRAINE – ALL THINGS NOT GOOD!" Trump then slammed India with a tariff of 25 per cent—to kick in on August 7—and warned that he would be imposing an additional penalty if India continued to buy oil from Russia. A day later, in yet another post on social media, Trump said he did not care if India and Russia "take their dead economies down together". On August 6, Trump